MINORITY AFFAIRS

A MAJOR GAP

Existing schemes aside, the Centre must take an earnest look at minority welfare

By Kaushik Deka

THE MINISTRY of Minority Affairs under the PM Modi-led government has received mixed opinions over the last few years, with fund allocation being a key area of criticism. In the last financial year, the budget estimate for the ministry was Rs 5,020.5 crore, which was later revised to Rs 2,612.66 crore. Until March this year, only Rs 712.5 crore was utilised. This year's budget at Rs 3,097 crore is 38 per cent lower than last year's initial allocation. Many have also condemned the discontinuation of schemes such as Padho Pardesh, Naya Savera, the Maulana Azad National Fellowship and a sizable component of the Pre-Matric Scholarship.

However, several steps have also been taken for minorities, particularly on the gender front. In education, as many as 30 per cent reserved seats for minorities are now earmarked for girls. Some 40,000 women have been trained under Nai Roshni, a leadership development scheme, since 2019. Also, as many as 4,314 women will perform Hajj without male companions this year, the largest since the 2018 reform did away with the rule. ■

BOLD & BRAVE

4,314

No. of women to go on Hajj without male companions this year, the largest since the rule was struck down in 2018

BUT...

The ministry's budget has been slashed by 38 per cent this year over last year's initial allocation

FY24 ₹3,097 crore

FY23 ₹5,020 crore

TRIBAL AFFAIRS

BOLD & BRAVE

1 MILLION

No. of tribal youth who will be digitally upskilled under the Going Online as Leaders 2.0 initiative

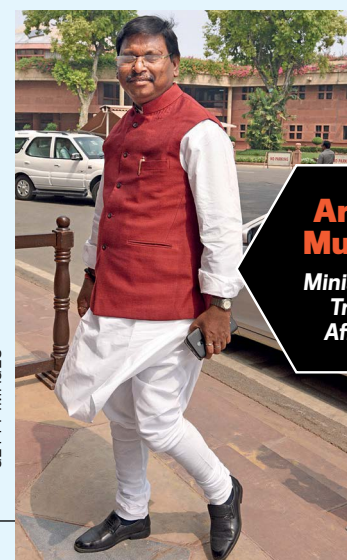
BUT...

- **Clash between Forest (Conservation) Rules, 2022 and Forest Rights Act, 2006 pose land use challenges to tribals**

Overlooked No More

The year 2022 marked many firsts for tribals

By Sonali Acharjee



Arjun Munda
Minister of Tribal Affairs

GETTY IMAGES

THE YEAR 2022 saw several key milestones for India's tribals. The country elected its first Adivasi president, set up the first research institute for tribal issues and put renewed focus on their welfare. The budget outlay for the Ministry of Tribal Affairs, led by Arjun Munda, increased from Rs 4,296 crore in 2013-14 to Rs 6,815 crore in 2019-20 and Rs 12,462 crore in 2023-24.

Education and livelihood are key focus areas. Launched in 2020, Going Online as Leaders, a joint effort by the Centre and Meta, aims to digitally upskill 1 million tribal youth in its second leg that started last year. The ministry is also helping tribals from the Northeast market their products.

On the health front, there are now 15,041 Ayushman Bharat centres in 177 tribal districts. In addition to the Tribal TB drive last year, under which 10 million people were screened for TB, regular health camps are also being held in tribal areas. ■